CASE STUDY · PRODUCT DESIGN

notebookCRM

Designing one workspace where independent creators prove their numbers, pitch brands and get paid.

Role	Timeline	Platform	Methods
Product designer	**October 2026**	**Desktop web app**	**Competitor, forum and API research**



The Overview screen brings performance from every connected platform into one view.

Overview

Independent creators run a small business with one workflow: track metrics, find a brand, pitch, follow up, quote a rate and send an invoice. Today that workflow is spread across Linktree, a spreadsheet, Gmail threads, a Notion deal tracker and a separate media kit.

notebookCRM connects those steps in one place. The product is built around a single loop: **Proof Block → Pitch → Follow-up → Deal → Invoice**. My research found no competitor that covers this loop from the creator's side.

The problem

The issue creators describe is not a lack of features. It is the manual work of moving information between tools that don't talk to each other.

"The biggest issue wasn't lack of features it was fragmentation."

r/influencermarketing

Three failures came up repeatedly:

Failure	Evidence
Stats are rebuilt by hand for every brand	"Right now I'm just screenshotting my Insights and it looks kind of messy."
Media kits go out of date	"...it is really a struggle to keep the info up to date." (Canva user)
Pitches get no follow-up	In one audit, 46 of 50 creator pitch emails had no follow-up plan.

Market context

Brands are projected to spend $32.6B on creators in 2026, and 45.5% of influencer spend is expected to go to micro and nano creators. At the same time, 48.7% of US creators earn under $10,000 a year. The product has to feel and be priced like prosumer software, not an enterprise platform.

$32.6B

Brand spend on creators, 2026

45.5%

Projected share of spend going to micro and nano creators

48.7%

US creators earning under $10,000 a year

Who it's for

I defined three personas from forum research. The first is the primary user; the other two shaped the pipeline and deal features.

The mid-tier multi-platform creator Primary

20K to 150K followers on two or three platforms, two to eight brand deals a month, no manager. Wants to look professional to brands without losing a day to admin. Assembles stats by hand whenever a brand asks, and finds that numbers from different platform dashboards don't match.

"...a tool, where I would enter my Social Media accounts... and it spits out a one pager with all my numbers, nicely layout and always up to date."

The UGC outreach operator

Sells content as a service and needs no audience. Sends cold email at volume, often with a virtual assistant, and stitches together outreach tools, contact-finders and a spreadsheet. Measures outreach like a sales pipeline: deliverability, reply rate, positive replies, calls booked and close rate.

"finding the right contacts is honestly the hardest part."

The spreadsheet deal tracker

YouTube-first, with occasional deals. Moved from Google Sheets to Notion and linked deals, deliverables and invoices by hand so nothing would be missed.

"The biggest upgrade for me was linking deals → deliverables → invoices so nothing slips."

Competitive landscape

The market splits into two halves that don't meet. Creator-side tools present the creator to brands. Brand-side tools help brands manage creators. Neither supports the creator's own business workflow.

Capability	Linktree	MediaKits.com	Later Influence	notebookCRM
Built for	Creators, small businesses	Creators	Brands, agencies	**Creators**
Media kit	No	Yes	No	**Auto-generated**
Cross-platform metrics	Link clicks only	Yes	Brand-facing	**Normalized**
Pitch sending and tracking	No	No	Brand-side only	**Yes**
Automatic follow-ups	No	No	No	**Yes**
Deal pipeline	No	No	Brand-side	**Creator-side**
Invoicing	Product sales only	Unverified	Brand-side	**Stripe**
Price	Free to $35/mo	Unverified	~$28,500/yr (estimate)	**Prosumer**

Each competitor pointed to a design opportunity:

- **Linktree** has over 70M profiles, but its analytics measure link clicks rather than the creator's business, and reviews complain about billing and cancellation. Transparent billing is an inexpensive way to stand out.
- **MediaKits.com** is the closest analog. Its founders named pitching as a top frustration but shipped only the analytics half before Viral Nation acquired the company in 2022. The pitching half was never built.
- **Later Influence** (formerly Mavrck) is strong campaign software built for brands, with no self-serve signup, four to six weeks of onboarding and enterprise pricing. It serves the buyer, not the creator.

Design principles

1. **Freshness is visible.** Every number shows when it was last synced.
2. **Averages over outliers.** Default to last-10 averages and medians, which brands trust more than a single high-performing post.
3. **One loop, one place.** A creator can go from a stat to a sent pitch to an invoice without leaving the app.

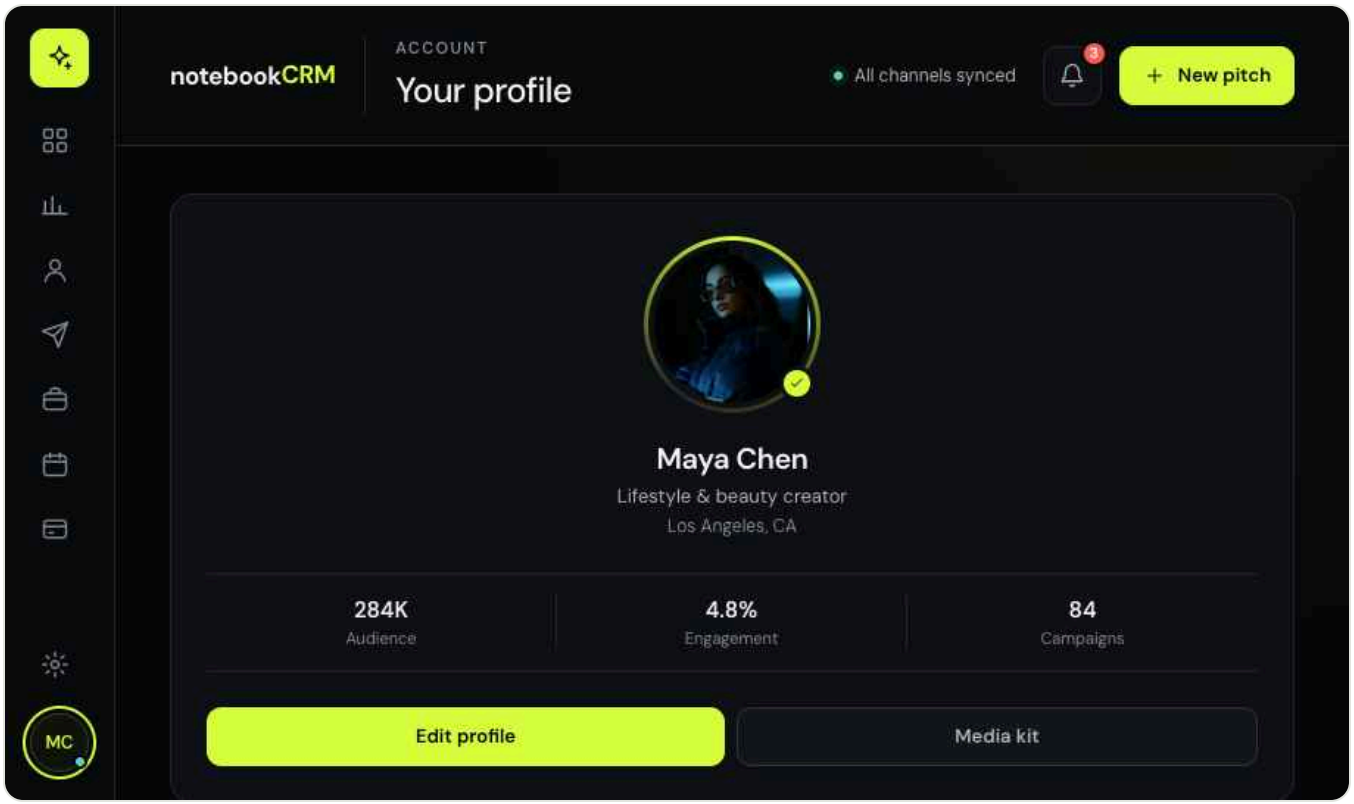
4. **Least privilege, explained.** Ask only for the permissions needed, and explain why in plain language.
5. **Honest gaps.** When a platform doesn't provide data, say so rather than leaving a blank.
6. **Transparent billing.** Clear pricing and one-click cancellation.
7. **Creator-first tone.** Written for the person selling, not the brand buying.

The solution

The product rests on three pillars, each matching one part of the creator's workflow.

1. Prove: a unified metrics ledger

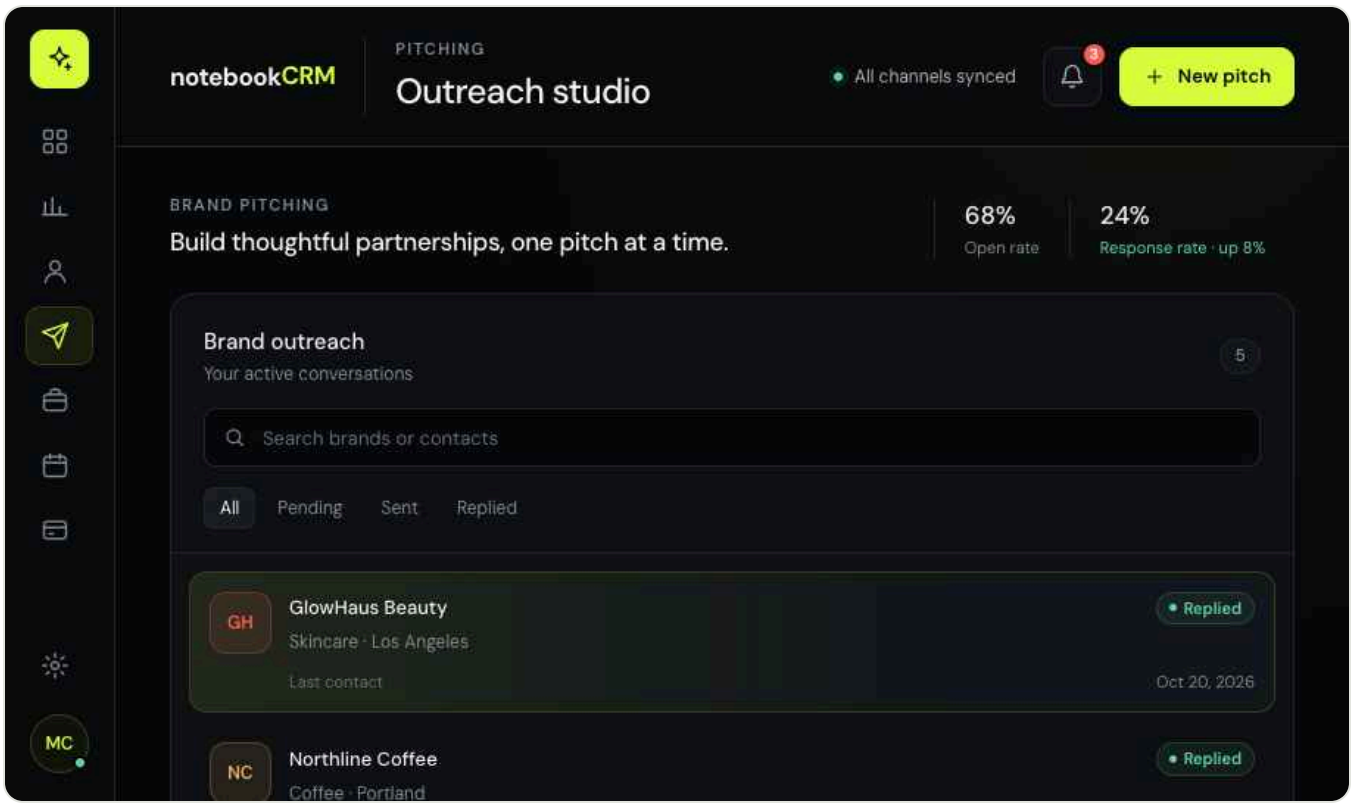
Creators connect Instagram, TikTok and YouTube once and see normalized views, engagement rate, saves, shares and follower change. Performance is shown as averages and medians over the last 10, 30 and 90 posts. Key numbers become Proof Blocks: small live stat cards that can be dropped into a pitch, media kit or rate card so they never go out of date.



The Profile screen shows connected accounts with sync times, typical performance by platform, audience breakdown, rate card and testimonials.

2. Pitch: a two-way pipeline

Creators write and send pitches from their own Gmail and track opens, clicks and replies. Follow-up sequences run on day 1, 4, 10 and 14, each attaching a different Proof Block, and stop when the brand replies. Each brand moves through Pitched, Opened, Replied, Negotiating and Won or Lost. A public profile link lets brands send structured collaboration requests that land in the same pipeline.



The Pitching screen pairs the brand list with the email editor so research and writing happen side by side.

3. Get paid: rate card and invoicing

The rate card lists "starting at" prices per deliverable, with bundles and usage rights quoted per campaign. Brands prefer this middle ground: no pricing reads as open to heavy negotiation, while a rigid price sheet locks the creator in. Suggested rates draw on the creator's engagement rate and niche benchmarks. Each won deal links to an invoice and a Stripe payout.

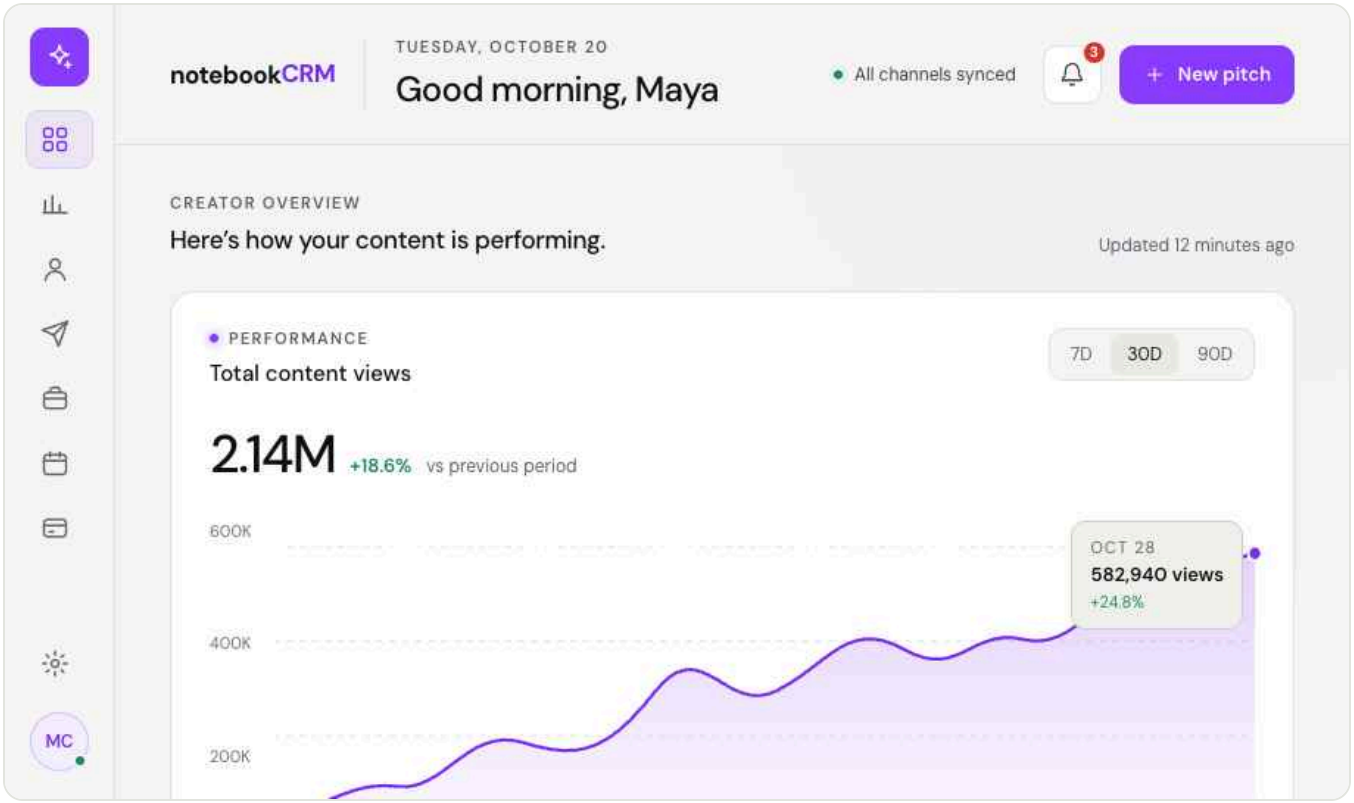
Designing around platform constraints

Platform APIs set firm limits on what the product can show. I reviewed each one and designed the interface to be honest about the gaps.

Platform	Constraint	Design response
Instagram	Only Business or Creator accounts can connect. The "impressions" metric is deprecated.	Check account type at connection, with a guide to upgrade. Label the metric "Views."
TikTok	No audience demographics. App approval can take weeks.	Show "Not available from TikTok" instead of a blank. Cache data and show sync times.
YouTube	Daily quota of 10,000 units.	Refresh on a schedule rather than live, with a "last synced" time.
Gmail	Sending is a sensitive scope; reading mail requires a security assessment.	Request send-only access and explain why. Detect replies through a tracking reply-to address, with a manual "Mark as replied" option.
Stripe	Identity checks (KYC) are required for payouts.	Hand off to Stripe's own onboarding and show payout status in the app.
Brand contacts	No official source; scraped data is about 70 to 80% accurate.	Start with manual entry and CSV import. Contact discovery comes later.

Visual system

The interface uses DM Sans throughout, with a lime accent in dark mode and violet in light mode. Navigation is a single sidebar, and an animated indicator moves between screens so the analytics and pitching areas read as one product.



Light mode switches the accent to violet.

Measuring success

- Time from a brand's request to a sent media kit or pitch
- Pitch reply rate and positive reply rate
- Share of pitches that receive at least one follow-up
- Deals won per month
- Days from invoice to payment

Next steps

The Overview, Pitching and Profile screens are designed. The media kit, pipeline board, rate card editor and invoicing screens are next. Before committing to the roadmap, I plan to:

- Interview 10 to 15 creators to decide which pillar to lead with.
- Test the Gmail send-only setup, including reply detection, before building on it.
- Verify competitor pricing that is currently based on third-party estimates.

Research sources include public pricing pages, G2, Capterra and Trustpilot reviews, creator communities on Reddit, eMarketer and other 2026 creator economy reports, and official Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, Gmail and Stripe developer documentation. Names and figures in the screens are example data.